



Merit Education Group

Prime Time — Variable Match

PBIS Game Master · Algebra 1 Unit 1 Lesson 1

Game Overview

A fast-paced card matching game where students pair variable expressions with their verbal descriptions. Students race to match expression cards to description cards, reinforcing the connection between algebraic notation and real-world language.

Players		3–4 per group
Time		10 minutes
Setup		1 minute

Materials

-  Pre-printed card sets (included below)
-  Scratch paper
-  Pencils

How to Play

1.
Shuffle each set of cards (expression cards and description cards) separately. Place them face down in two piles.
2.
Player 1 flips one card from each pile — one expression and one description.
- 3.

If the expression matches the description, the player keeps the pair and goes again. If not, they flip both back face down.

4.

Play passes clockwise. The next player takes a turn flipping one card from each pile.

5.

The game ends when all pairs have been matched. The player with the most pairs wins.

Scoring

Correct match: +1 point per pair

PBIS Bonus: +1 bonus point for encouraging a teammate or explaining a match to the group

Bonus limit: Maximum 2 PBIS bonus points per player per round

Sample Cards

Expression → Description

$n + 8$	→	"A number plus eight"
$3x$	→	"Three times a number"
$2y - 5$	→	"Five less than twice a number"

Teacher Notes

- Circulate among groups to observe matching strategies and note common misconceptions.
- Encourage math talk: ask students to explain **why** an expression matches a description before awarding the pair.
- Use PBIS recognition cues: "**Great teamwork — I like how you explained that match!**" or "**Nice persistence — you kept trying until you found the right pair.**"
- For struggling groups, limit the card set to 4 pairs instead of 6.

- For extension, ask students to create their own card pair.

PBIS Skill: Cooperation & Academic Engagement